TRANSNET
rail infrastructure manager

TRIM Advances Rail Reform with TOCs Onboarding and Expanded Network Access

[Johannesburg, 13 May 2026] — The Transnet Rail Infrastructure Manager (TRIM) has successfully concluded Rail Access Agreements (RAAs) with all 11 Train Operating Companies (TOCs) that were allocated slots, marking a major milestone in South Africa's rail reform journey.

The new TOCs are: ARC South Africa (ARC), The Railway Corporation, TLD Marine, Menar Ports & Rail, Sharp Logistics, Barberry, Grindrod, Minrail, IRACEMA, Motheo Logistics, and Interlinks, spanning key sectors such as coal, manganese, containers, fuel, and general freight, collectively driving diversification and competitiveness across the network.

This achievement increases the number of active operators on the national rail network from one to twelve, spanning five strategic corridors. The allocations are expected to introduce an additional 24 million tonnes (Mt) of freight capacity to the network, with the potential to scale to 52mt over the next five years, supporting the national objective of increasing rail volumes from approximately 180mt to 250mt by 2030.

"This milestone represents more than just slot allocation, it signals the creation of a functional and competitive rail marketplace. We have moved from policy design to practical implementation, enabling real private sector participation and investment in rail," said TRIM Chief Executive, Moshe Motlohi.

In December 2025, TRIM introduced the Ad Hoc Slot application process, an innovative, rules-based mechanism that enables rapid allocation of rail capacity outside the annual cycle.

This process has already unlocked new opportunities, including a proposed short-haul service between Cato Ridge and Durban aimed at reducing road congestion in the port precinct. The service is targeted to commence operations in May 2026.

"The Ad Hoc Slot process is a game-changer. It allows operators to respond to real-time demand while maintaining the highest standards of safety, transparency, and efficiency," said Motlohi.

Engagements are currently underway to onboard and assist the new TOCs with operational readiness. Some TOCs are targeting to commence operations before the end of 2026, while the remaining operators are expected to be operational during the course of 2027.

This collaborative process has also enhanced the bankability of rail projects by incorporating feedback from both operators and financial institutions. The insights gathered are informing ongoing improvements to Network Statement Version 4, which is currently at an advanced stage of finalisation.

As TRIM continues to refine its access framework through Network Statement Version 4, the focus remains on scaling participation, enhancing operational efficiency, and unlocking further investment into the rail sector – building a modern rail ecosystem that is competitive, accessible, and aligned with South Africa's economic growth ambitions.

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ISSUED ON BEHALF OF TRANSNET RAIL INFRASTRUCTURE MANAGER (TRIM)